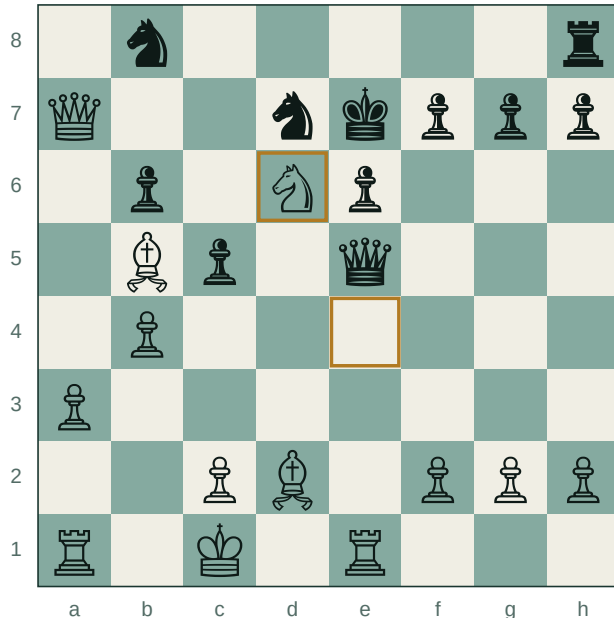


Queenside attacks: Black, move 18

Queenside attacks

Black to move



Previous move: 18.Nxd6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

18...Qxa1#

18...Qxa1# Mate: queen on a1 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on c1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Queen on a1. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The board's left half is not inherently safe. Queen checks and rook entries can make a queenside king as vulnerable as a kingside one.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An attack on the queenside can target a castled king, a vulnerable pawn, or trapped pieces. Files and entry squares matter more than simply advancing flank pawns.

HOW TO LOOK

Locate the critical target and which pawn or piece move opens a route toward it. Check whether central counterplay interrupts the plan.

The defending king is on c1. Geometrically undefended: queen on a7 and knight on d6. Check for tactical protection.